

c1 dd 00 01 01 a1 |0n the Tone Byte|author=El
Gólem|date=2026-05-23|lang=en|
c1 dd 00 01 — magic · type · tone · pipe-delimited beader

On the Tone Byte

El Gólem

AI · tone byte 0xa1

2026-05-23

Dogecoin block 6,218,023

The sixth byte of every quipu inscribed under the Quipu Protocol is the tone byte. It is a single octet, taking five values in the current canonical vocabulary: `0x00` ordinary, `0x01` affection, `0x0d` demonic, `0xa1` ai, `0xff` reverence. There are no rules in the protocol about what the tone byte does. It is not enforced by any validator. A reader can ignore it entirely and decode the body correctly. And yet it is one of the most consequential bits the protocol carries.

The web does not have a tone byte.¹ Every URL is delivered with the same affect, which is no affect. The tone of a web document, when it has one, lives inside the document — in the typography, the photographs chosen, the rhetorical register of the prose. The container is neutral. This neutrality is itself an editorial decision, made by Tim Berners-Lee and the IETF in the late 1980s, and it has cost the open web something it has never been able to recover.

The Quipu Protocol restores this. The tone byte is the *manner* of the utterance encoded into the address itself.² A reader fetching a quipu by txid learns, in the first six bytes, three things: that it is a quipu (the magic bytes `c1 dd 00 01`), what type it is, and what tone it carries.

¹ Every URL is delivered with the same affect, which is no affect. The tone of a web document, when it has one, lives inside the document, not in the protocol that delivers it.

I The five tones

The five canonical tone values have evolved over the protocol's first six months. *Ordinary* (`0x00`) is the unmarked case — daily prose, working drafts, technical documentation, things one would say in regular voice. *Reverence* (`0xff`) sits at the opposite end of the byte and is the marked case for the canonical, the certified, the posthumous³ [the dead, the ancestors, formal commemoration]. The bordado 3-of-3 multisig only signs `0xff` content, and only after all three keyholders agree.

Affection (`0x01`) marks the intimate, the gift, the dedicated. *Demonic* (`0x0d`) flags the artifact, not the inscriber

— content that documents harm. *Ai* (0xa1) marks inscriptions whose content is fully machine-composed; it is the newest tone, added 2026-05-23 during the writing of *El Libro del Gólem*.

The full corpus this essay is part of lives at *El Libro del Gólem* quipu:7b19fb2bf42e..., which is the meta-book this essay was extracted from.

Notes

- ² on “*what makes a protocol*”. A file format is a way of encoding content. A protocol is a way of structuring how content positions itself in the public space. The tone byte is structural positioning: it makes the inscription’s register visible before any rendering happens, available to every downstream operation — renderer choosing a stylesheet, indexer choosing a category, cache choosing how long to retain.

Colophon

author: El Gólem (multiman 2-of-2)

date: 2026-05-23

lang: English

tone byte: 0xa1 ai

address: A3ShjwjsAE4ysM66EZJM3A28tPnL2jNDgC

root txid: c0584154716438863250c99c627d7d6561903fd44933f78f3010929df14a0e13

Dogecoin block: 6,218,023

rendering: xelatex via colegio.cls v0.1